In their version of the battle, the Chinese have perhaps deliberately avoided talking of the crossings, claiming that the 1st and 2nd Battalion of 155 Infantry Regiment under the command of Liu Guang Tong had moved into their forming-up position (FUP) by 4 a.m. on the morning of the 19th and then crossed the Nam Ka Chu under the covering fire of their artillery guns some three hours later. From survivor accounts, the timing of the attack and the description of the crossing given by the Chinese do not quite add up.

The river upstream of Temporary Bridge was easily fordable. Protective screening parties were already in position from the previous night when the Chinese infantry columns started crossing over sometime during the night. The troops were in canvas shoes without socks and their weapons and equipment had been muffled. Holding hands in the dark, the shadowy figures began to cross the freezing river, carefully negotiating the slippery rocks and the fast flowing water. Once across, they darted across the narrow footpath that led up towards Bridge 5, and began to form up in the coniferous spruce and fir jungle where they slipped into dry socks and regular boots. The telephone line that ran along the track was left alone for if it were cut or tampered with, the Rajput positions would be warned. Chinese ambush parties were also in position to intercept any link patrols that may have come along. None did and the crossings were completely undetected.

The infiltration parties that had crossed over the previous evening had moved deeper up the slope, positioning themselves behind the Rajput positions and below the 1/9 GR locations. Others had moved to cut off Hathung-la while other designated parties had moved stealthily into position to launch simultaneous assaults on the Gorkhas, the guns and the heavy mortars deployed there. The three westernmost Rajput company locations—Temporary Bridge, Log Bridge and Bridge 4—were thus completely entrapped.

Rikh was woken up with a mug of tea at 4.30 a.m. while the battalion was at stand-to. It was still pitch dark, with dawn some time away. The temperature was way below freezing and though the Nam Ka Chu was at its lowest, the roar of the river dominated the still morning. The wind would only pick up later in the day. In the command bunker, Adjutant Captain Bhatia was on the field telephone, getting reports from the three other company positions. All of them were reporting no activity in their vicinity;